

Mauritania



Two-thirds of Mauritania's territory is desert – the only productive land is that drained by the Senegal River. The country has taken a strongly Arab direction since 1964.



GEOGRAPHY

The Sahara, barren except for some scattered oases, covers the north. Savanna lands lie to the south.



CLIMATE

The climate is generally hot and dry, aggravated by the dusty *harmattan* wind. Summer rain in the south, virtually none in the north.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The majority Maures control political and economic life. Family solidarity among nomadic peoples is particularly strong. Ethnic tension centers on the oppression of the sizable black minority by Maures. Tens of thousands of blacks are estimated to be in illegal slavery.

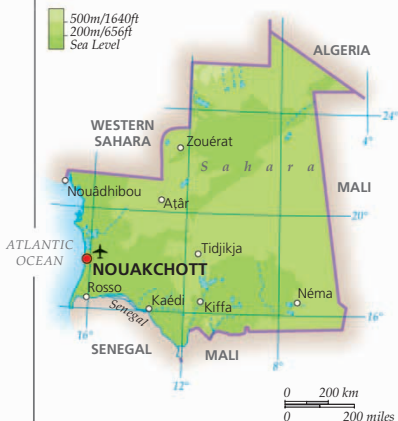


INSIGHT: Slavery officially became illegal in Mauritania in 1980, but *de facto* slavery still persists



THE ECONOMY

Agriculture and herding. Iron, copper, and gold mining. World's largest gypsum deposits. Offshore oil from 2006. Rich fishing grounds.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Islamic Republic of Mauritania

DATE OF FORMATION: 1960

CAPITAL: Nouakchott

POPULATION: 3.29 million

TOTAL AREA: 397,953 sq. miles
(1,030,700 sq. km)

DENSITY: 8 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Hassaniyah Arabic*, Wolof, French

RELIGIONS: Sunni Muslim 100%

ETHNIC MIX: Maure 81%, Wolof 7%,
Tukolor 5%, other 4%, Soninka 3%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Ouguiya = 5 khoums